

tactics, you realise how strong he [Brij Bhushan] is politically. There were others before us who tried to speak up, but they paid a price. A physiotherapist tried to complain in 2014, but he had his name and that of his wife, who was training, cut out.

People ask us "*ab kyun?*" [Why now?]. I believe there is a right time for everything. At the 2022 World Junior Championships, too, there were incidents of wrongdoing with girls. We decided that enough is enough, we have to protest. Bajrang [Punia] and Vinesh [Phogat] had spoken to home minister Amit Shah last year after winning their CWG medals, but there was no action.

There are others too, but we spoke up because we believe that God has given us a lot and made us capable of doing this. There are mid-career athletes or those who are just starting out, who fear that there will be repercussions.

Q. Some claim that the protesting wrestlers didn't want to participate in selection trials and thus want Singh arrested.

Do you really think any of us can go for a competition without a trial? There are others who are working hard and everyone has a right to contest for the spot. In my wrestling career so far, I have never gone for a competition without a trial, and played the nationals. He [Singh] will say anything in order to save himself.

Q. The PoCSO complaint was recently withdrawn. Was the person not a minor at the time?

The statement changed under duress. Her father has clearly said she is a minor and that they are under pressure.

Q. Are attempts being made to break your resolve?

Yes. Wrong news is being spread that the protest has been withdrawn or that I or Vinesh [Phogat] have pulled out from it. These are false rumours that are being spread so that our protest can be ended. Bajrang had earlier received calls to leave and [was told] that he'd get what he wanted. But we are united and will continue our fight.

Q. What are your plans for the future? Will you want to take to coaching and create a safe space for wrestlers?

I haven't thought of it. I have my own *akhara* where I train and where I'd like to train the future generation. There's no plan to join the WFI. But there must be greater representation of women in federations so that women's issues can be addressed freely.

name, of our marriage, of our income. We are not from a culture where such things are openly talked of," she says.

Those who have spoken have done so at considerable cost. Vinesh, for example, is also the sole earning member of her immediate family. She was only nine when her father was shot dead and later witnessed her mother's struggle with cancer, but she found a father figure and mentor in her '*tauji* [elder uncle]', Mahavir Singh Phogat. The Phogats—five brothers, their families and a dozen children—all lived in one dilapidated house till the girls' success changed their material fortunes. Mahavir had initially trained his four daughters—Geeta, Babita, Sangeeta and Ritu. His grit in making wrestlers out of them would be chronicled in the blockbuster film *Dangal*, featuring Aamir Khan as Mahavir. It was Vinesh who made the biggest impression on Mahavir; she was more fearless than his daughters, he said, and did things from her heart. And though Mahavir's daughter Babita, who is also a BJP leader, has distanced herself from her sisters in the cause, Mahavir, who is also in the BJP, remains a staunch supporter of his niece. He says he will return his own medals if she doesn't get justice.

Fear of reprisal and concerns about their careers deterred all from a complaining at the time the offences were committed

Malik's life has been slightly different from the Phogats. She comes from a relatively well-off family from Mokhra village in Haryana's Rohtak district. She began training at the age of 12 after being inspired by her uncle who was also a wrestler. In an earlier interview with INDIA TODAY, she talked of sharing a stuffy gym full of intimidating men and heavy with the